



A climber for two where players bid contracts and 10s shovel sets

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Concept

Dopplin is a two-player climbing and shedding game played with a shortened double deck.

Players lead and beat singles, pairs, sets, runs, and connected sets. There are no bombs. Instead, 10s can shovel an opponent’s set into your hand, leaving the 10s behind as the new active play.

Before play begins, players bid for contracts that raise the stakes and set the terms of the hand: who leads, how set-aside cards enter play, and what the declarer must achieve. Victory comes from reading your hand, choosing the right contract, and knowing when to shed quickly, when to hold back, and when to shovel.

Setup

Players: 2.

Cards: Use 2 standard 54-card decks and keep only the 5s, 10s, Js, Qs, Ks, As, 2s, and Jokers, excluding all Diamonds.

This gives exactly **46 cards**: 6 cards each of 10, J, Q, K, A, and 2, plus 4 ordinary 5s, 2 Heart 5s, 2 Small Jokers, and 2 Big Jokers.

Deal: Deal **18 cards** to each player. Set the remaining **10 cards** aside face down, unused except as noted by certain contracts.

First bidder: Randomly choose the first bidder for the first hand. In later hands, the player with fewer points bids first. If scores are tied, the player who did not score the previous hand bids first.

Card Rank

Highest to lowest: Heart 5 > Big Joker > Small Joker > ordinary 5s > 2 > A > K > Q > J > 10.

The **Heart 5** is separate from the ordinary 5s. It cannot combine with ordinary 5s in pairs and sets. The two Heart 5s may still pair with each other.

Jokers may be played as singles or as same-kind pairs. They are not used in runs or connected sets.

Contracts

Before play, starting with the first bidder, players alternate chances to declare. A player may **pass** or declare a contract stronger than the current one. The auction ends when a player passes after a contract has been declared, when both players pass with no contract declared, or immediately when **Heavenly** is declared.

If both players pass, play **Quiet**. If a contract is declared, the player who declared the final contract is the **declarer**.

In every declared contract the declarer’s aim is **to shed out before the non-declarer**. Unless a contract states otherwise, the declarer leads first and fails if the non-declarer sheds out first. The table lists only what each contract adds or changes.

Contract order: Quiet < Breakaway < Forced Shovel < Clean Hands < Buried Treasure < Red Finish < Blackout < The Chase < Shutout < Heavenly.

Contract	Requirement
Quiet	No declarer. The first bidder leads first. The first player to shed out wins.
Breakaway	No added conditions.
Forced Shovel	Declarable only if the declarer holds at least one 10. Whenever a legal shovel is available, the declarer must perform it. Otherwise, the declarer may play 10s only in their final play. To succeed, the declarer must shovel at least once or include 10s in their final play.
Clean Hands	The declarer may not use shovel. Doing so is an immediate failure.
Buried Treasure	Before play, reveal the top 3 set-aside cards. The non-declarer chooses either 1 or 2 of them and adds the chosen cards to their hand. The declarer takes the remaining revealed card or cards.
Red Finish	The non-declarer leads first. The declarer’s final play must contain the Heart 5.
Blackout	The non-declarer leads first. The declarer may not lead singles. Doing so is an immediate failure. Beating a single with a single remains allowed.
The Chase	Before play, the declarer takes the top 3 set-aside cards into their hand. The non-declarer leads first. The declarer must shed out before the non-declarer escapes. The non-declarer escapes the moment they have fewer than 3 cards after playing on their turn. Shoveling cannot trigger escape.
Shutout	The declarer must shed out before the non-declarer plays any card. If the non-declarer plays any card first, including a shovel, the declarer fails immediately.
Heavenly	The declarer must complete a Shutout. Then, after the declarer’s final play, the non-declarer gets one last chance to beat or shovel it. If they can, the declarer fails. Otherwise, the declarer succeeds.

Turn Flow

When **leading**, play any legal combination. You may not pass. When **responding**, either pass, play a legal combination that **beats the current play**, or **shovel** (see Shovel). If the opponent passes, the last player who played clears the pile and leads again.

The hand ends the moment a player makes their final play, or earlier through contract failure or non-declarer escape. The opponent cannot beat or shovel this final play, except in Heavenly.

Legal Plays

Play	Requirement
Single	1 card.
Pair	2 equal-rank cards. The two Heart 5s may pair. Same-kind Jokers may pair.
Set	3 to 6 equal-rank cards, where available: triple, quad, 5-, or 6-of-a-kind.
Single run	Exactly 4 or 5 consecutive singles, using only 10, J, Q, K, A.
Connected sets	3+ consecutive equal-size groups: connected pairs, triples, quads, 5-, or 6-of-a-kind groups. Only 10, J, Q, K, A may be used.

Comparison: A play only beats the **same type** with matching size, length, and structure, and only if it is **strictly higher**. Equal does not beat equal. Singles, pairs, and sets compare by rank. Runs and connected sets compare by their highest card or highest group. Connected sets must match both group size and number of groups.

No bombs: There are no bombs and no cross-type beating.

Shovel

10s have a special **shovel** power. On your turn, you may play 10s to capture the opponent's current pair or set if your 10-play has exactly one fewer card than the target.

Shovel play	Captures
10	A pair.
10-10	A triple.
10-10-10	A 4-of-a-kind.
10-10-10-10	A 5-of-a-kind.
10-10-10-10-10	A 6-of-a-kind.

The captured cards are added to the shoveling player's hand. The played 10s stay on the pile as the current active play. The opponent must now beat the 10s or pass.

Example: Opponent plays Q-Q-Q. You play 10-10. You take Q-Q-Q into your hand. The active play is now 10-10.

A shovel may only capture the opponent's current play. You cannot shovel your own earlier play.

Limits: Shovel may capture only pairs and sets of ordinary ranks: 10s, Js, Qs, Ks, As, 2s, and ordinary 5s. It cannot capture Heart 5s or Jokers.

Scoring

Scoring format: Success / Failure. If the declarer succeeds, they score the first value. If they fail, the opponent scores the second value.

Contract	Score
Quiet	9
Breakaway	15 / 10
Forced Shovel	18 / 12
Clean Hands	24 / 16
Buried Treasure	27 / 18
Red Finish	42 / 28
Blackout	48 / 32
The Chase	54 / 36
Shutout	96 / 64
Heavenly	108 / 72

Card bonus: The player who scores the hand also scores 1 additional point for each card remaining in the opponent's hand, capped at the contract score they receive. No card bonus is awarded for Shutout or Heavenly.

In **Quiet**, the first player to shed out scores 9 points plus the card bonus.

Match: Play to **150 points** for a short match, or **250 points** for a longer match, or to any previously agreed number of hands or points. If playing to points, the match ends after a hand in which a player reaches the target.

Design Notes and Credits

Dopplin is mainly inspired by Dalian Red 5, with additional inspiration from Big A and Dou Dizhu.

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